



Providing a Service

When clients sign up for a service, they do so on trust. Unlike buying a product, there is nothing to handle or see before they part with money. Every aspect of your service must meet, or exceed, their expectations.

Making promises

Providing services involves using your skills and knowledge to satisfy the needs of your clients—you and what you do must meet their expectations. Because of this, the relationship between you and your clients is closer—and more important—than it is for a business that sells a product. By offering a service, you are making a promise to do something for your client and satisfy their needs.

In order to run a successful service-based business, you must thoroughly understand your clients' requirements and do everything you can to make their experience of buying from you a positive one. You must also convey a sense of trustworthiness—that you will at least deliver on your promise, and

hopefully even exceed it. Examine and analyze all the various stages your client will have to go through as part of their experience with you, from seeing your marketing material to using your service and their satisfaction with it afterward.

Identifying expectations

When planning your business, always consider the services you intend to offer from your clients' perspective. For example, if you are planning a dog-grooming service, think about the level of service you would expect yourself from such a business, the kind you would be happy to receive, and what would encourage you to return there. If you intend to target a particular clientele with your service, such as older or more affluent people,

research their requirements carefully, because their needs are likely to be very specific.

It is important that you are clear about exactly what your clients will receive when they sign up to, and pay for, your service. To ensure clarity, write an SLA (Service-Level Agreement), which defines and agrees the commitment between you and your client in terms of service quality, responsibilities, and availability.

How to create a successful service

Maintaining a strong relationship with your clients is central to running a successful service business. Treat relationship building as an ongoing process—one that is essential to growing a loyal client base. Take time to understand your clients' needs. Be prepared for those needs to change, and look for ways to adapt, enhance, or add to the services you offer in order to keep clients interested. Most important, always be honest, since the relationship relies on trust, which is easily lost.



MAKING IT WORK

- › **Stay in touch** with your clients after the initial service; for example, by sending newsletters that will be useful or interesting to them.
- › **Keep looking for ways** to improve your service, and keep up-to-date with whatever is happening in your business sector.
- › **Regularly try your competitors' services** to see what they do, and how you can surpass their offerings.
- › **Deal with problems** immediately and try to put things right for clients.
- › **Maintain your passion** for what you do to generate enthusiasm and to make your clients feel excited about experiencing your service.
- › **Remain alert for related services** you could offer; for example, if you are a personal fitness instructor, you could also offer a sports massage service or nutrition advice.